

TENDER AND EXOTIC PLANTS

Gardeners have long been fascinated by tender and exotic plants that bring color and interest from all corners of the world. In warmer regions, many of these can be grown in the garden; in cooler areas, they're best treated as houseplants, at least for part of the year.

What are tender and exotic plants?

This group of plants originates from many parts of the world, including tropical and subtropical areas, where they require temperatures no lower than 34–64°F (1–18°C), even in winter. Their specific cultural demands vary between plants and can be complex. In addition to warmth, many also require high light levels, long growing seasons, and often either very arid or humid growing conditions. A small number, including cacti and succulents, can tolerate frost if kept dry, but most cannot.

Where the climate allows, tender and exotic plants can be grown in the garden; where it doesn't, they must be grown indoors. The most tender plants require permanent protection and are commonly grown as houseplants, including flamingo

flower (*Anthurium andraeanum*), peace lily (*Spathiphyllum wallisii*), and Madagascar jasmine (*Stephanotis floribunda*). Other plants are more robust and can spend the summer in sheltered positions in the garden, being brought back in before the first frosts. These include *Banksia coccinea*, the Australian heath (*Epracris impressa*), and king protea (*Protea cynaroides*).

Designing with tender plants

The range of tender and exotic plants is vast, and includes many with bold flowers, attractive foliage, or an architectural habit. With such a diverse variety to grow, they are ideal for many different situations and planting styles. In areas where they can be grown outdoors all year, they can form the

mainstay of beds and borders, even entire gardens, from jungle schemes to desert-style borders. In cooler areas, where they can only spend the warm summer months outside, they can still play a prominent role. Pot-grown plants such as *Agave americana*, *Ensete ventricosum*, and even the bird of paradise, *Strelitzia reginae*, for example, will all give a dramatic but temporary display in the garden, or on a patio or roof terrace.

Indoors, tender and exotic plants can be put to many uses, from statement plants in grand reception rooms, and year-round greenery in conservatory planters, to lone windowsill potted plants for seasonal color.

BELOW Dramatic foliage

The Japanese sago palm (*Cycas revoluta*) is one of many tender shrubs that can be enjoyed indoors during winter, but can be kept outside for summer. It is grown for its sculptural foliage and habit.



ABOVE Exotic flowers for indoors

Frangipani (*Plumeria rubra*) is famed for its rich scent and must be grown permanently in a large heated conservatory, where it can become very large. It needs a minimum winter temperature of 50°F (10°C).



ABOVE Conservatory climber

Bougainvillea is a vigorous, shrubby climber in warmer climates. It needs a minimum temperature of 45°F (7°C), and must be treated as a large conservatory plant in cooler areas.

